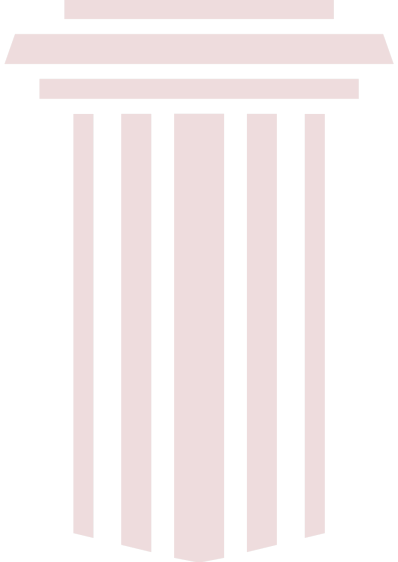




Atlas

Getting the Words Right





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First Edition, 2025

Preface

This book began as notes. Notes on what makes writing work. Notes on why some essays land and others don't. Notes on the difference between words that impress and words that convince.

Umarbek Umarov and Husan Isomiddinov took these notes while teaching students how to write personal essays. The students needed clear guidance. They needed examples. They needed someone to show them what good writing actually looks like.

Those notes became this book.

The book has one purpose: to help you write better. Not fancier. Not longer. Better. It will show you how to find what matters in your experience, how to put it on the page clearly, and how to revise until the words are right.

This book is part of Agora's mission: building the sharpest pens in the region. Sharp writing cuts through noise. It shows readers exactly what you mean. It doesn't waste their time.

The principles here apply to personal statements, but they work for any writing that needs to be clear and convincing. Whether you're writing an essay, an email, or a report, the same rules matter: simple sentences, concrete details, ruthless editing.

We wrote this book the way we teach: with examples that show rather than tell, with rules you can apply immediately, and with respect for how hard good writing actually is.

If you follow the process (pre-writing, drafting, revising), your writing will improve. Not because of magic, but because of hard work.

Let's begin.

Acknowledgments

This book exists because of a great team of people who helped build it.

SATashkent believed in this campaign from the start. It was just some rough notes and raw, unfiltered ideas initially. But SATashkent's partnership provided us with the resources and time to transform those notes into something students would actually benefit from using. Without their support and investment, these pages wouldn't exist.

The students we've taught over the months showed us what was good advice and what wasn't. Their input lies in our core architecture: examples of each concept. Their need for practicality prevented us from getting too abstract at times (which, we admit, would be a huge issue). They helped us understand the needs of our potential readers. This book reflects what they taught us about writing. Without them, we would miss the targeted benefit.

Writing teachers before us (William Zinsser, George Orwell, Ernest Hemingway, Joan Didion, Annie Dillard) left teachings we borrowed and adapted. We built on their foundations rather than starting from scratch. So this book is not new. It simply builds on their writing philosophy, but makes it more compatible with the needs of our audience.

Our families gave us the time to learn English, to study, to improve, and to write. Time we could be forced to spend elsewhere. That matters more than acknowledgements usually say.

About Agora

Agora is a knowledge lab dedicated to helping students think clearly and write powerfully.

Agora takes its name from ancient Greek gathering places where people exchanged ideas and made societally-significant decisions. We intend to build on that tradition by creating spaces where learning occurs through conversation, feedback, and, especially, writing.

Why Writing? Education should teach you how to think, not just what to think. So writing sits at the center of this mission. Clear writing reveals clear thinking. Strong writing demonstrates intellectual depth. Being able to articulate complex ideas using simple language sets apart those who understand from those who merely memorize.

Beyond writing, Agora is slowly migrating towards fulfilling its role as a knowledge lab. We have recently launched Agora Talks, a reading club that discusses ideas and explores the works of philosophers such as Camus and Heidegger, as well as futurists like Ray Kurzweil.

We also started a Walk-and-Talk club, dedicated to bringing together like-minded folks and exploring the greenery of the city.

We are also working on bringing AI into our mission to achieve our version of “singularity” in the human area of creativity. We call it Andromeda, an AI tool meant to amplify brainstorming, not replace it.

But regardless of the mission, our vision remains the same: helping students develop the intellectual tools to succeed in any field that demands clear thought and precise communication.

Thank you for becoming a part of our community by reading this book.

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Pre-Writing

A: WHAT YOU SHOULD DO BEFORE WRITING

"The time to begin writing an article is when you have finished it to your satisfaction. By that time, you begin to clearly and logically perceive what it is you really want to say." —Mark Twain

Most students think: "I need to write my personal statement. Let me open a document and start with 'Ever since I was little...'"

Stop right there. This approach is backward.

Your personal statement doesn't start when you type the first word. It starts when you figure out what makes you genuinely different from the 50,000 other applicants.

And to know what makes you genuinely different, you need to think. A lot.

The Problem With Writing Too Soon

Writing without thinking first is like trying to get someone's attention at a party by talking about your GPA. Sure, it might impress someone. But it won't make you memorable.

Admissions officers read hundreds of essays about overcoming challenges, helping others, and learning life lessons. They're not looking for another version of the same story. They're looking for your specific way of seeing the world.

H.L. Mencken nailed this problem: "One and all, they lack the primary requisite of the imaginative author: the capacity to see the human comedy afresh, to discover new relations between things, to discover new significance in man's eternal struggle with his fate."

Translation: Most people can't see the world in a new way. They fail to find fresh connections between things or see new meanings in everyday life.

Finding those fresh connections takes time. Time spent thinking.

Right now, your brain is full of experiences. But they're not organized. They don't mean anything yet. If you start writing before you figure out what they mean, everything will sound generic.

When you write without thinking first, two things happen:

1. You write the essay everyone has already read a thousand times (cliché city).
2. You waste 650 words telling admissions officers what they already know from your application.

What Makes You Different?

Most students have similar experiences. Playing sports. Doing volunteer work. Moving to a new place. Dealing with family stuff.

So what makes your personal statement unique?

Thinking.

Thinking differently.

Thinking from a different angle.

Let us show the difference.

The generic approach:

"When I moved to the United States, it was very hard for me. The food was different and I didn't know the language, so it was difficult to make friends and go to school. I really missed my home, but after some time, I joined some activities like music and drawing and felt happier. These hobbies made me feel better and helped me adjust to a new country."

This is vague. Flat. It just states things that happened without giving any insight into how the writer thinks.

The thoughtful approach:

"Moving to America was like going from freshwater into saltwater. Not only did my mom complain that American food was too salty, but I was helplessly caught in an estuary of languages, swept by daunting tides of tenses, articles, and homonyms. It's not a surprise that I developed an intense, breathless kind of thirst for what I now realize is my voice and self-expression.

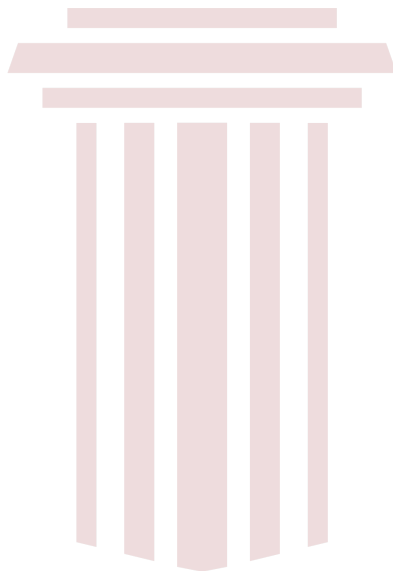
I later learned in biology that when a freshwater fish goes in saltwater, it osmoregulates—it drinks a lot of water and urinates less. This used to hold true for my school day, when I constantly chugged water to fill awkward silences and lubricate my tongue to form better vowels. This habit in turn became a test of English-speaking and bladder control: I constantly missed the timing to go to the bathroom by worrying about how to ask. The only times I could express myself were through my fingers, between the pages of Debussy and under my

pencil tip. To fulfill my need for self-expression and communication, I took up classical music, visual art, and later, creative writing. To this day, I will never forget the ineffable excitement when I delivered a concerto, finished a sculpture, and found beautiful words that I could not pronounce. If biology helped me understand, art helped me be understood.”

Did you see the difference? This writer took time to think about their experience from multiple angles. They connected biology to language learning to art. They found a fresh way to describe something common.

That's what thinking does. It transforms ordinary experiences into insights.

Remember: Your personal statement is thinking made visible. If you haven't done the thinking part, you're not ready to write.



B. DISCOVERING YOUR AUTHENTIC SELF

Morning Pages

Morning pages come from Julia Cameron's book "The Artist's Way" (1992). The practice is simple: three pages of unfiltered writing, first thing in the morning. No editing. No judging. Just you and a blank page.

The practice became wildly popular among successful creators. Screenwriter Brian Koppelman calls it "the closest thing to magic" he's found for accessing his most creative work. Authors Tim Ferriss, Austin Kleon, and Elizabeth Gilbert all credit morning pages with transforming their creative processes.

Morning pages are raw, unfiltered, spontaneous writing you do before trying to write your actual essay. They bypass the voice in your head that says, "This isn't impressive enough," or "They don't want to hear this." They let you dump out your real thoughts and feelings before your inner censor kicks in. They let you migrate away from your "performative" self.

Writing forces thought into language. When ideas stay in your head, they remain fuzzy, half-formed, protected by the fog of intention. You *think* you know what you believe, but you haven't tested it.

The moment you write "I care about environmental justice," you're forced to confront what that actually means. Do you? Why? What specific aspect? When did you start caring? What made you notice it in the first place?

Morning pages make you answer these questions before you're trying to impress anyone. They're thinking made visible: messy, honest, unpolished thinking that reveals what you actually care about beneath the performance.

Most students skip this step. They sit down to write their essay and immediately start performing: reaching for words that sound smart, ideas that seem impressive, stories that feel "college-worthy." But performance blocks discovery. You can't find your authentic voice while trying to sound like someone else.

Morning pages separate these two processes. First, you think. Then, you write for an audience.

The goal of a morning page is to figure out what you actually *think* and *feel*.

How to Do It

Open a blank document. Set a timer for 15, 30, or 45 minutes. Write about your prompt or topic. Don't edit. Don't judge. Don't worry about grammar or whether it's "good enough." Just write.

Write the messy version first. Write about the thing that actually changed you, even if it seems small. Write about the moment you felt something shift. Write about what you're afraid to admit.

And if you have nothing to write, write "I have nothing to write" till something comes out.

Examples

- You think your story is about winning a soccer tournament, but your morning pages reveal it's actually about the friendship you built with your rival
- You plan to write about how your family moved, but the real emotional core is the plant you left behind in your old garden
- You intended to discuss your volunteer work, but what actually matters is how it made you question your privilege
- You plan to write about how you won that regional math olympiad, but the background story is more interesting: finding a proper teacher to train with.

After you finish: Read what you wrote. Circle the parts that feel paradoxical, contractive, or surprising.

That's your gold. That's your authentic self. That's the real you that others would find interesting.

And that's what you'll polish for your real essay.

Elements of a Personal Statement

Harvard's Director of Admissions, Marlyn McGrath, once praised an admitted student: "His essay reminds us that he is a person who loves books and loves reading and loves ideas... What surprised us was his enthusiasm for talking about this book with other students."

This reveals what admissions officers actually want to see. Your essay must demonstrate two things:

-
1. **Someone who loves learning.** You need to show genuine intellectual curiosity about something specific.
 2. **Someone with personality.** You need to write in a way that reveals who you are as a person.

Someone Who Loves Learning

This is your chance to show that you've developed a specific academic interest through real experiences, can articulate exactly what you want to study, and think deeply about ideas that fascinate you.

Most students write generic statements about wanting to "help people" or "make a difference." Boring.

Instead, an engineering student might write about designing a water filtration system for their community, connecting thermodynamics principles to environmental justice issues they've observed. A psychology student might explore how cognitive load theory explains why phonics-based instruction works better for certain learning differences they encountered while tutoring.

The pattern is always the same: ***You notice something interesting. You can't let it go. You investigate further using academic frameworks. You end up with insights that surprise even you.***

When you run a school fundraiser, don't just describe the logistics. Analyze the behavioral economics principles (e.g., barbell strategy and social proof) that made your campaign strategy work. This shows you think like someone who belongs in college classrooms.

Writing clearly

This is a chance to reveal your specific personality through concrete details and compelling writing. Not through adjectives or generalizations.

Don't tell admissions officers you're "curious" or "hardworking." Show them through scenes that only you could describe.

Example 1: One student writes about collecting vintage mechanical pencils, not because they're nostalgic, but because they're fascinated by how different mechanisms affect the relationship between thought and paper. Their 1960s Pentel P205 produces lines that make them think more carefully than their laptop ever could.

This specific detail reveals someone who pays attention to how tools shape thinking. The writing shows they can express complex ideas clearly.

Example 2: Another student describes the moment their little brother asked why adults cry at weddings if they're supposed to be happy. That five-minute conversation changed how they read poetry; they started looking for moments when authors capture contradictory emotions simultaneously.

The writing captures both the innocence of the question and the sophistication of the insight it led to.

Example 3: One student admits they read instruction manuals for fun, not because they love following rules, but because they're curious about how different minds approach the same problem. IKEA assumes you think spatially. Japanese electronics manuals assume you think sequentially. These differences fascinate them more than the actual products.

The best personal details are humble and specific, expressed with a genuine voice.

Your writing should sound like you are talking to someone you trust about something you care about. After reading your essay, admissions officers should feel like they've met someone they'd want to live down the hall from, someone whose particular way of seeing the world would make conversations more interesting.

The Right Balance

Your primary focus should be on writing well and revealing your personality, with a secondary focus on intellectual curiosity and academic goals.

Compelling personality and writing take up the most space, while intellectual curiosity shows you're ready for serious academic work.

Most failed essays focus too heavily on academics and career goals without enough personality. They sound like research papers:

"I want to study computer science to develop AI systems that can help diagnose medical conditions. Through my internship at a local hospital and my work developing a symptom-checking app, I've learned that machine learning algorithms can process patient data more efficiently than traditional diagnostic methods..."

Snooze fest.

A successful essay balances both elements naturally:

”My grandmother always insisted that computers would never understand human intuition. 'Machines can't feel a mother's worry,' she'd say when I tried to show her medical websites. I used to argue with her until the day I watched her correctly diagnose my cousin's appendicitis twenty minutes before the doctors confirmed it. That moment made me realize that the most interesting problems in medical AI aren't technical, but they're about translating human intuition into algorithmic form. Now, when I code diagnostic tools, I think about my grandmother's hands on my fevered forehead, asking questions no database would know to ask.”

This works because we see a compelling personality through the relationship with the grandmother and specific memories, while intellectual curiosity shows through thinking deeply about AI limitations.

Before You Write

Answer these two questions clearly:

1. What complex idea, question, or academic concept genuinely excites your mind, and what specific field do you want to study to explore it further?
2. What specific, unusual, or endearing thing about your personality would make someone want to be your friend, and can you write about it in a way that sounds authentically like you?

If you can't answer both questions clearly, you're not ready to write yet.

C. INTELLECTUAL DEVELOPMENT

Research

College admissions officers see thousands of essays about sports victories, volunteer work, and family hardships. They don't need another story about your grandmother who passed away or how you learned teamwork from basketball.

What they need is evidence that you think like a scholar.

You're applying to work with professors who have spent decades studying complex ideas. These professors have written books, conducted research, and made discoveries. They want students who can engage with challenging concepts and contribute to academic discussions.

When admissions officers read your essay, they're asking: "Will this student thrive in our classrooms? Will they ask thoughtful questions? Will they connect ideas in ways that surprise us?"

This means your essay needs to show intellectual curiosity, not just personal growth.

Instead of writing about how drama club taught you confidence, write about how studying character motivation in Shakespeare made you notice the psychology behind everyday conversations.

Instead of writing about overcoming fear of public speaking, write about how you discovered that rhetoric techniques from ancient Greece still influence modern political debates.

One approach shows you as someone who had experiences. The other shows you as someone who thinks deeply about experiences and connects them to bigger ideas.

Mix Ideas

Most students focus too much on their major. They write about their love of biology or their experience in student government, or their part-time job. These essays feel flat because they don't show how your mind actually works.

Real thinking happens when you connect ideas from different domains.

Think about cooking. Salt by itself tastes like salt. Pepper by itself tastes like pepper. But when you combine salt, pepper, garlic, herbs, and other ingredients, you create complex flavors that couldn't exist without all the parts working together.

Your experiences work the same way.

Say you play violin and work at a hardware store. By themselves, these are just activities. But when you connect them, you might discover that both taught you how small adjustments make huge differences (whether you're adjusting finger position on strings or helping a customer measure materials for their project).

This connection reveals something about how your mind works. You notice details others miss. You see patterns across different situations. You understand that mastery in any field requires attention to small but crucial elements.

Another example: You play chess and babysit younger kids. Most students would write about one or the other. But what if you noticed that both activities made you think several steps ahead? In chess, you anticipate your opponent's moves. When babysitting, you anticipate what might go wrong and prepare solutions in advance.

This connection shows that you naturally think strategically, whether in a game situation or a caregiving situation.

The key is spending time thinking about these connections before you write.

Don't just list your activities. Ask yourself:

- What skills do these different experiences have in common?
- What patterns do I notice across different areas of my life?
- How has learning in one area helped me in a completely different area?

Where to Find Ideas

Method A: Academic Research

SSRN contains thousands of research papers written by professors and graduate students. These papers explore cutting-edge ideas that haven't made it into textbooks yet.

How to use it:

1. Go to ssrn.com and search for topics related to your academic interests

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- Psychology: "cognitive bias," "decision making," "social behavior"
 - Economics: "behavioral economics," "market psychology," "consumer choice"
2. Read abstracts only (short summaries of main findings). Don't try to read entire papers unless something really catches your attention. You're looking for ideas that spark curiosity, not trying to become an expert.
 3. When you find an interesting abstract, ask yourself:
 - How does this connect to my own experiences?
 - Does this research explain something I've observed in my life?
 - Does it challenge something I've always assumed was true?

Example: You find research showing that people make different decisions when choosing for themselves versus choosing for others. This might remind you of helping friends pick classes or college applications. You could write about how you noticed this pattern in your own life, then discovered that researchers have studied it extensively.

The goal of this is to use their work as a starting point for your own thinking, not to steal anything.

Method B: Faculty Bio Pages

Every college has faculty bio pages describing what professors are researching. These pages are goldmines for understanding what excites academic minds in your field.

The process:

1. Choose colleges you're interested in attending
2. Go to their websites and find the department pages for your intended major
3. Read bio pages for 5-10 professors

Pay attention to what they're studying right now, not just past achievements. Look for phrases like "current research," "recent projects," or "areas of interest."

Example: Say you want to study environmental science. You might find:

- A professor studying how urban heat islands affect public health
- Another researching microplastics in food chains
- Another examining how climate change affects migration patterns

Now think about your own experiences. Have you noticed anything related to these research areas?

- Maybe you've observed how different neighborhoods in your city have different temperatures
- Maybe you've wondered about the plastic water bottles your family uses
- Maybe you've thought about how weather changes affect your community

You could write an essay connecting your personal observations to the kinds of research happening at universities. This shows admissions officers that you notice the same patterns and ask the same questions that drive professional researchers.

The key is not to pretend you're conducting research at a professor's level. Show that you ask the kinds of questions they ask.

Method C: Academic Journals

Academic journals publish the most current research in every field. Unlike textbooks (established knowledge), journals contain new discoveries and ongoing debates.

How to approach journals without getting overwhelmed:

1. Start with journals that publish shorter, more accessible articles:
 - The Atlantic
 - Scientific American
 - Harvard Business Review
2. Once comfortable, explore more specialized journals:
 - Psychology: *Psychological Science*, *Current Directions in Psychological Science*
 - Biology: *Nature* or *Science* (focus on shorter news sections)
3. Always start with abstracts and conclusions. These tell you main findings without requiring you to understand all the methodology and statistics.

Example: You find research showing that people are more creative when slightly bored than when highly stimulated. This reminds you of your best ideas coming during long car rides or while doing mundane tasks. You could explore this connection in your essay, using the research as a lens for understanding your own creative process.

You're not trying to become an expert on the research. You're using it as a tool for understanding your own experiences and thinking more deeply about topics that interest you.

Learning from Professional Writers

Professional writers in publications like *The Atlantic*, *The New Yorker*, *The Economist*, and *Harper's* have mastered making complex ideas engaging. They know how to hook readers, build arguments, and create memorable conclusions.

How to learn from them:

Read articles regularly, but read them as a writer, not just as a consumer. Pay attention to:

- How they start their articles
- What makes you want to keep reading
- How they transition between ideas
- How they end their pieces

Most professional articles follow certain patterns. They often start with a specific story or example, then zoom out to explain why this example matters for a bigger issue. They use concrete details to illustrate abstract concepts. They anticipate reader questions and address them before readers get confused.

Try this exercise:

1. Find an article you enjoyed reading
2. Read it again, but this time ask:
 - What techniques did the writer use to keep my attention?
 - How did they explain complicated ideas simply?
 - What examples did they choose and why were those examples effective?
3. Practice using similar techniques in your own writing
 - If the professional writer started with a surprising statistic, try starting your essay with a surprising observation from your life
 - If they used an analogy to explain a complex concept, practice creating your own analogies

The goal here is to understand the underlying principles that make writing engaging and clear.

Working with Primary Sources

Most students reference the same famous quotes and well-known historical examples. This makes their essays blend together. Using archival sources gives you access to perspectives and examples that other applicants won't know about.

Archives contain original documents, old articles, letters, and other primary sources that aren't widely circulated. Many archives are available online through university libraries or historical societies.

Instead of quoting FDR's famous "The only thing we have to fear is fear itself," you could find articles written about FDR during his presidency that show how people actually reacted to his leadership at the time. Contemporary accounts often contain insights that aren't in modern textbooks.

Instead of writing about Mark Twain's famous novels, you could find articles he wrote for magazines in the 1880s and 1890s that reveal his thinking on topics like luck, success, or human nature. These lesser-known pieces show different sides of his personality and give you unique material to work with.

Instead of quoting Steve Jobs' Stanford commencement speech, you could find early product memos from <https://www.folklore.org/0-index.html> that show how design and hardware designs were actually decided internally. That blog reveals thinking processes beyond public outcomes.

Use these archival sources to support your own insights, not just to show off obscure knowledge. Find historical perspectives that illuminate modern questions or connect to your personal experiences in unexpected ways.

When an admissions officer sees that you've engaged with original sources and primary documents, they understand that you think like a researcher. You don't just accept secondhand interpretations. You go to the source to form your own understanding.

Testing Your Understanding

Before you write about any complex idea, test whether you truly understand it by explaining it in simple terms.

There is a saying: “If you can't explain something to a ten-year-old, you don't understand it well enough to write about it convincingly.”

It's true. You should understand what you are writing (e.g. academic concepts, or theories) so clearly that you can use simple language and everyday analogies to make them accessible.

Practice

Take a concept from your intended field of study and try to explain it using only common words and familiar examples.

- **Economics:** Try explaining supply and demand using concert tickets or cafeteria food
- **Psychology:** Try explaining cognitive bias using examples from social media or friend groups

The process of creating simple explanations often reveals gaps in your own understanding. You might realize you've memorized definitions without truly grasping the underlying concepts. This is valuable feedback that helps you study more effectively.

Once you can explain ideas simply, you can choose how much complexity to include in your writing based on your audience. For a college admissions essay, you want to show that you understand sophisticated concepts, but you also want to communicate clearly enough that any educated reader can follow your thinking.

D. ORGANIZING YOUR THINKING

Structuring Ideas

Before you start writing, spend time organizing your thoughts logically. Think like an architect who plans the foundation, supports, and structure of a house before beginning construction.

Some ideas are foundational that everything else depends on understanding them first. Other ideas are supporting structures that build on the foundation. Still others are finishing touches that complete the picture but only make sense once the foundation and supports are in place.

Example: If you're writing about how social media affects teenage relationships, you might need to establish what you mean by "relationship" before you can discuss how technology changes relationship dynamics.

Example: If you're writing about environmental policy, you might need to explain the basic science of climate change before you can discuss specific policy solutions.

Think about your reader's journey through your ideas:

- What do they need to understand first?
- What will confuse them if you introduce it too early?
- Where will they need examples to make abstract concepts concrete?
- Where will they need breaks to process complex information?

Most weak writing happens when writers dump all their ideas on the page in the order they thought of them, rather than in the order readers need to encounter them.

Strong writing guides readers step by step from familiar territory to new understanding.

Instead of focusing *only* on what you want to say, think carefully about what your reader needs to hear and in what order they need to hear it.

Before you write, map out your reader's likely mental journey:

- What do they probably believe or assume when they start reading?
- What misconceptions might they have?
- What evidence will they need to accept new ideas?
- What objections might they raise?

Your job is to anticipate these reactions and address them proactively.

If you're arguing for an unusual interpretation of a historical event, acknowledge the conventional view first, then explain why your perspective offers additional insight.

If you're describing a personal realization that contradicts common assumptions, help readers understand what led you to question those assumptions.

This approach makes your writing more persuasive because readers feel like you understand their perspective and are helping them discover new ideas, rather than lecturing them or showing off your knowledge.

Creative Constraints

Try giving yourself specific limitations before you write. Maybe you can only use examples from daily life. Maybe each paragraph can only contain three sentences. Maybe you have to explain every concept through questions rather than statements. Maybe you can only use words with two syllables or fewer.

These constraints sound restrictive, but they often lead to more creative and memorable writing. When you can't rely on fancy vocabulary or complex sentence structures, you have to find other ways to make your ideas compelling. You focus more on clarity, precision, and originality.

Professional writers often use constraints deliberately:

- Some newspaper columnists limit themselves to exactly 750 words
- Some magazine writers challenge themselves to explain complex topics using only common vocabulary

These limitations force creativity and clarity.

Experiment with different constraints to see which ones help you write more effectively. You might discover that artificial limitations reveal strengths in your writing that you didn't know you had.

E. PRACTICE

Daily Practice

Your writing improves through daily habits, not just through concentrated writing sessions. Creativity is like fitness; you build strength through consistent practice, not occasional intense workouts.

Morning Brain Food

Every morning before checking your phone, do three things to feed your brain new material.

First, read something completely unrelated to your normal interests.

- If you usually read news, read poetry
- If you usually read fiction, read science articles
- If you usually read about your intended major, read about art or history or cooking

Your brain needs diverse inputs to create original outputs. When you only consume information from one domain, your thinking becomes predictable. Cross-pollination between different fields often produces the most interesting insights.

Second, write down three things that surprised you yesterday.

Not major surprises, but small observations that made you think:

- Maybe you noticed how people's walking speed changes when it rains
- Maybe you realized that your mood affects how music sounds to you
- Maybe you observed how your pet reacts differently to different family members

These micro-observations are raw material for interesting writing. They show that you pay attention to details that others overlook. They demonstrate the kind of curiosity that makes for engaging essays.

Third, ask yourself one question you can't answer immediately.

Not practical questions like "What should I wear today?" but bigger questions that require real thinking:

- Why do some people feel energized by crowds while others feel drained?

-
- Why do certain colors seem to have emotional associations?
 - Why do you trust some strangers instinctively but not others?

Write the question down, but don't try to answer it right away. Let it percolate in your mind throughout the day. Often your best insights come when you're not actively trying to solve the problem.

Midday Mind Wandering

When your brain gets tired from focused work, resist the urge to immediately distract yourself with social media or entertainment. Instead, take a walk without any input (no music, podcasts, or phone calls).

This mental downtime is when your brain processes information and makes unexpected connections. The morning question might connect to something you read. A surprise from yesterday might relate to a conversation you had. An idea from class might illuminate a pattern you've noticed in your family.

When interesting thoughts arise during these walks, jot them down quickly. Don't worry about making them perfect or complete. Just capture the essential idea so you don't lose it.

These fragments are often your most valuable creative material. They represent your unconscious mind working on problems and making connections that your conscious mind couldn't force.

Evening Pattern Recognition

Before you go to sleep, review all the fragments you collected during the day. Read through your morning question, your surprise observations, and your walking thoughts. Look for connections and patterns.

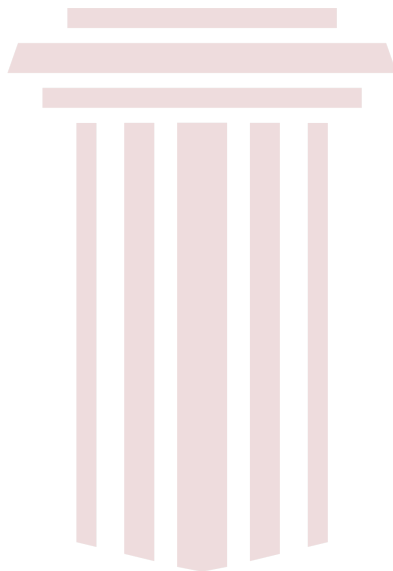
Maybe you keep noticing how people react to unexpected situations. Maybe you keep thinking about how technology changes social behavior. Maybe you keep wondering about the difference between what people say and what they actually do.

These recurring themes reveal what your mind naturally wants to explore. They show you the questions and topics that genuinely fascinate you, as opposed to the topics you think you should be interested in.

Choose one pattern that feels most compelling. That becomes your focus for tomorrow's observations and thinking.

Over time, these daily practices help you develop a deep understanding of topics that truly engage your intellectual curiosity.

This approach works because it mirrors how professional researchers and writers actually develop their ideas (through sustained attention to questions that matter to them, combined with constant exposure to new information and perspectives).



F. CONCLUSION

When You Know You're Ready to Write

There's a moment when you feel you're ready to write.

It's when your idea won't leave you alone. When you keep thinking about it while you're doing other things. When you find yourself explaining it to people without meaning to.

This is different from having an application essay due tomorrow. That's panic, not readiness.

Real readiness feels like pressure building up inside your head. The idea wants to come out. You're not forcing yourself to write. You're finally letting yourself write.

When you reach this point, something interesting happens. Writing doesn't feel like creating something from nothing. It feels like copying something that already exists in your mind onto the page.

The Test

Ask yourself this question about your idea:

"What would have to be true about the world for this idea to be not just correct, but important?"

Let's break this down with an example. Say you want to write about how social media makes people lonely.

The question becomes: "What would have to be true about the world for this idea to be not just correct, but important?"

Your answer might be:

- Humans would have to be social creatures who need real connection to be happy
- Technology would have to be changing how we connect
- The changes would have to be making us worse at forming deep relationships
- This would have to be happening to lots of people, not just a few

If you can answer this question clearly, you understand not just what you think, but why it matters. You understand the bigger picture your idea fits into.

If you can't answer this question, you're not ready to write yet. You're ready to think more.

As Joan Didion put it, "You just lie low and let them develop. You stay quiet." Stay quiet until the ideas are ready. When they are, it becomes impossible to contain them.

When you have something worth saying, and you understand why it's worth saying, the words come much easier.

Chapter Summary

The entire chapter exists to answer one question: **How do you find something genuinely worth saying?**

Everything else (morning pages, research, mixing ideas, daily practice) is just a method to get there.

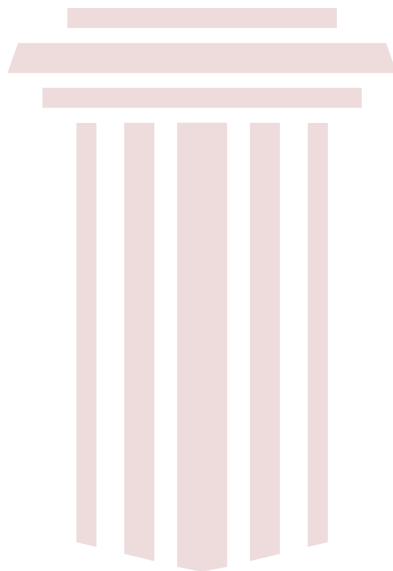
Most students have similar experiences: playing sports, volunteering, moving to new places, and dealing with family challenges. What makes your essay different isn't what happened to you. It's how you *think* about what happened to you.

Generic experiences become authentic through authentic thinking. Moving to a new country is common. But connecting that experience to osmoregulation in biology, then to art as self-expression, that's a connection only you would make because of your specific combination of interests and observations.

Authentic thinking doesn't happen when you open a document and start typing. It happens when you create conditions for insights to emerge. Morning pages let you discover what you actually care about beneath the obvious story. Research across different fields (biology, economics, psychology, literature) gives you frameworks to see your experiences in new ways. Mixing ideas from separate domains reveals patterns, e.g., violin and hardware work both teach precision, chess and babysitting both require anticipating what comes next.

The daily practice of reading widely, observing carefully, and letting ideas connect during walks is how your brain finds the connections that no one else would find.

Everything in this chapter exists to help you reach that moment of discovery. Without it, you'll write the same essay as everyone else. With it, you are much more likely to write an essay that only you could write.





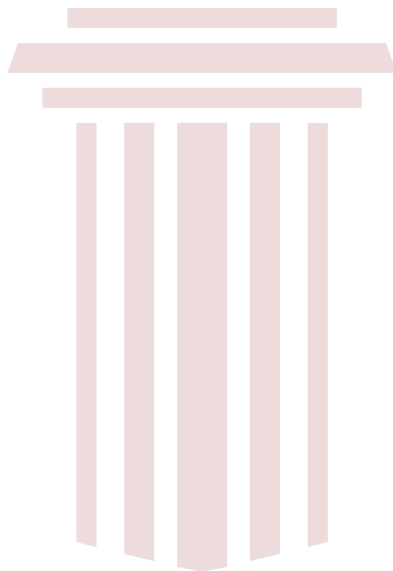
Writing

You should already have written **Morning Pages** about your experiences, researched your academic interests, and found out about the people or programs at the university that match your goals. All of which we covered in the first chapter.

If you have notes, questions, or reflections written down, you already hold the raw material for a strong statement.

The task now is to shape that material into writing that feels sharp, clear, and convincing.

And let's learn!



PART I: THEORY

What Makes Writing Good?

Good writing is simple, specific, brief, and authentic. That's it. The rest is technique for achieving these four things.

Most writers believe complex sentences sound smarter. They're wrong. Good writing shouldn't be about sounding intelligent, but by being clear.

The "Theory" section explains what great writing should be like. The rest of this chapter offers the "kill" rules to achieve it.

Simplicity

Your personal statement is thinking made visible. Simple sentences force clarity of thought because they leave no room for confusion.

Most thoughts are simple at their core, even the profound ones. "I think, therefore I am." "E=mc²." "The only thing we have to fear is fear itself." These ideas changed the world with simple words.

When you write "The coffee was cold," you've made a statement you must stand behind. Complex sentences let you hide in subordinate clauses and qualifications. Simple sentences demand honest thought.

Why We Avoid Simplicity

Often, the main reason people avoid simple sentences is that they're exposing. There's nowhere to hide.

A complex sentence: "Given the challenging circumstances and the multifaceted nature of the situation, it could be argued that the outcome was less than optimal."

A simple sentence: "We failed."

The simple version is terrifying. It's direct. It's clear. It puts you on the line.

We're scared of:

-
- **Being wrong.** If you say something simply, and it's wrong, everyone knows. Complex language creates ambiguity that protects you.
 - **Being obvious.** We think simple ideas aren't worth saying. But clarity often looks obvious in hindsight. That's the point.
 - **Being judged.** Simple sentences feel naked. "I want this." "I believe that." "This matters to me." No hedging. No escape routes.
 - **Being ourselves.** Simple language sounds like you. Your actual voice. Not the impressive version you're trying to project.

Good writing requires courage. It requires standing behind your words without qualification or camouflage.

The Standard

Ernest Hemingway rewrote the ending of *A Farewell to Arms* thirty-nine times. When asked what the problem was, he said: "Getting the words right."

That's what good writing is. Getting the words right. Not impressive words. Not complex words. Not words that sound smart. The *right* words, the ones that say exactly what you mean and nothing else.

Hemingway proved that simple sentences could be devastating. His prose had the force of a punch because every word carried weight. No padding. No decoration. Just the thing itself.

Simple sentences aren't simple to write. They're distilled. There's a difference.

Show, Don't Tell

Good writing shows rather than tells.

Don't write "She was angry." Write "She slammed the door."

Don't write "The room was messy." Write "Clothes covered the floor, yesterday's dishes sat on the desk, and something smelled like forgotten fruit."

Showing means giving readers the evidence and letting them draw conclusions. Telling means handing them the conclusion directly. Showing is harder but stronger. It makes readers active participants rather than passive receivers.

This is why good writing feels concrete rather than abstract. It deals in specifics, actual things, actual moments, actual words spoken, not in generalizations and summaries.

Examples:

Telling: "I was nervous about the presentation."

Showing: "My hands shook as I clicked to the first slide. I'd practiced this speech fifty times, but now every word felt wrong."

Telling: "The neighborhood was poor."

Showing: "Three houses on the block had boarded windows. A rusted playground stood empty. The corner store sold everything behind bulletproof glass."

The shown version gives you the scene. The told version gives you the label. Scenes stick. Labels don't.

Brevity

Good writing wastes no words. Every sentence should earn its place. Every word should do work.

This doesn't mean writing short. Hemingway wrote simply, but his novels run hundreds of pages. Brevity means density, maximum meaning per word, not minimum words overall.

When you write "very happy," you've used two words to create less impact than one: "ecstatic," "giddy," "jubilant." When you write "in spite of the fact that," you've used six words to say "although."

Examples:

Wordy: "At this point in time, it is important to note that the project, due to the fact that it was implemented in a manner that was less than optimal, did not achieve the results that were anticipated."

Brief: "The project failed because we implemented it poorly."

Wordy: "She engaged in the process of thinking about what she wanted to accomplish."

Brief: "She thought about her goals."

Wordy: "The reason why I chose to pursue this field of study is because of my intense interest in understanding how things work."

Brief: "I study engineering because I want to understand how things work."

Brevity respects your reader's time. It says: I've done the work of compression so you don't have to work at comprehension.

Voice

Good writing sounds like a person, not a committee. It has voice, a sense that a specific human being is speaking.

Voice comes from honest expression. When you write the way you actually think, when you use words you'd actually say, when you trust your natural rhythms. That's voice.

Most student writing has no voice because students are terrified of sounding unprofessional. They write "utilize" instead of "use," "implement" instead of "do," "commence" instead of "start." They inflate language because they think it sounds mature.

But good writing is the opposite. It's deflated to its essence. It sounds like you at your most articulate, still you, just your clearest version.

Examples:

No voice: "Upon reflection, I have come to the realization that the experience provided me with valuable insights regarding the importance of collaborative endeavors."

Voice: "Working with the team taught me something I couldn't learn alone: good ideas get better when you let other people challenge them."

No voice: "The aforementioned incident resulted in a significant alteration of my perspective."

Voice: "That day changed how I see the world."

The version with voice sounds like a human talking. The version without voice sounds like a form letter.

When admissions officers read thousands of essays, voice is what makes them stop. Voice is what makes them remember you. Voice is what makes them think: "I'd like to meet this person."

Putting It Together

These four principles (simplicity, showing, brevity, voice) work together:

- **Simple sentences** force clear thinking
- **Showing** makes ideas concrete
- **Brevity** eliminates waste
- **Voice** makes writing human

When you write a sentence like: "My grandmother's hands shook as she threaded the needle," that sentence is simple (one action), showing (you see the scene), brief (ten words), and voiced (it sounds like a person observed this).

Compare that to: "My grandmother, who was elderly and experienced the physical challenges associated with aging, attempted to engage in the process of threading a needle, which proved to be difficult due to her lack of manual dexterity."

Never forget Apple says, "Think different," not "Leverage cognitive reorientation strategies."

Same information. But the first version is good writing. The second is not.

What Comes Next

You now understand what makes writing good. The rest of this chapter teaches you how to achieve it.

First, you'll learn universal rules that apply to all writing, rules for killing wordiness, confusion, and bad structure.

Then, you'll learn how to apply these principles specifically to personal statements, which demand both craft and authenticity.

Let's get to work.



PART II: UNIVERSAL WRITING RULES

(These general rules apply to any type of writing, not just college personal statements)

Kill Philosophy

One of the most common writing mistakes is using too many words to say too little.

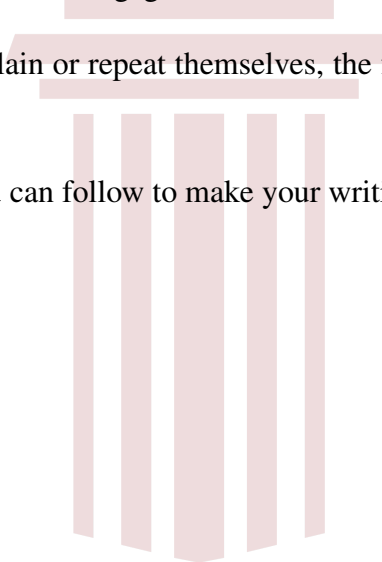
Ideal writing would use the fewest words possible to communicate the most meaning.

Think about a personal statement. It's usually limited to around 650 words. At first, that might feel like too little space to show admissions officers who you are. That's why you need to be as efficient as you can be with your words.

Now, "efficient" writing doesn't mean "short." There are 900-page books where every sentence is essential and worth reading. Efficiency simply means that nothing feels wasted; every line serves a purpose and keeps the reader engaged.

Because many people over-explain or repeat themselves, the first step toward stronger writing is cutting unnecessary words.

Here are a few simple rules you can follow to make your writing instantly better:



KILL WORDINESS

Rule 1: Kill Empty Words

We write the way we think, that's repetitive, all over the place, with too many fillers. Too often, we add extra phrases that feel professional or formal, but they're just taking up space. That's fine for a first draft. But then you've got to cut.

Simple rule: If a word can be removed without changing the meaning of the sentence, delete it.

Examples:

Before: "In spite of the fact that he was tired, he still went to the gym." After: "Although tired, he went to the gym."

Look what we cut: "In spite of the fact that" becomes "Although." Same meaning. Seven words → one word.

Before: "At this point in time" After: "Now"

Four words → one word. Zero meaning lost.

Before: "She is a woman who writes poetry." After: "She writes poetry"

We already know she's a woman. "Who writes poetry" is just a longer way to say "writes poetry."

Hit list of empty phrases:

- "I think that..." (We know you think it. You're saying it.)
- "It seems like..." (Does it seem or is it?)
- "Kind of..." / "Sort of..." (Commit to a position.)
- "Actually..." / "Basically..." (Usually meaningless)
- "Absolutely essential" / "Completely finished" (Redundant modifiers)
- "Past history" (History is inherently past)
- "At the end of the day..." / "At this point in time..." (Say "now")
- "What I'm trying to say is..." (Then say it)
- "It is important to note that..." (Just note it)
- "Utilize" / "Implement" / "Facilitate" / "Optimize" (Use simpler verbs: use, do, help, improve)

Rule 2: Kill Adjectives & Adverbs

"Show, don't tell" might be the most repeated advice in writing, yet it remains misunderstood.

Ernest Hemingway learned his style from journalism at the Kansas City Star, where the style guide demanded: use short sentences, active verbs, vigorous English. But mainly, cut the adjectives.

Why? Because adjectives are lazy. They tell instead of show, and they're a shortcut that weakens writing.

Take "beautiful woman." What does that mean? Nothing specific. Everyone pictures something different. But "her walk turned heads" shows something. It creates a picture and makes readers do the work.

Writers who rely on adjectives are like painters who explain their art: "This bit represents sadness. This bit represents joy." Don't explain. Show.

Hemingway wrote: "The old man was thin and gaunt with deep wrinkles in the back of his neck."

Not "the decrepit old man."

Adjectives (amazing, incredible, life-changing) and adverbs (really, very, truly, extremely) don't make your essay stronger. They make it weaker.

Too many adjectives and adverbs make writing sound childish or overexcited. Imagine telling an admissions officer: "I am very, very passionate about math." It sounds unconvincing. But if you describe staying up until 3 a.m. solving a math puzzle, your passion is clear without a single adjective.

When describing emotions or states, skip the label. Instead of writing "I was angry," describe what anger looks like from the outside: clenched jaw, short breaths, a door slammed too hard.

Think of it as the "don't say the word" game. To show confusion without naming it, you might write: "I read the same sentence four times." For exhaustion: "My eyelids felt like they had tiny weights attached."

Observe yourself as if you're watching through a camera lens. Then, write.

The adverb problem is particularly severe. Stephen King believes the road to hell is paved with them:

"The adverb is not your friend. They're like dandelions. If you have one on your lawn, it looks pretty and unique. If you fail to root it out, however, you find five the next day... and then your lawn is totally, completely, and profligately covered with dandelions."

Instead of "she ran quickly," find a better verb: "she bolted," "she sprinted," "she fled."

Exercise: After writing a draft, circle every adjective and adverb. Ask: "If I cut this, would the meaning weaken?" If not, delete it.

Rule 3: Kill Zombie Nouns

Professor Helen Sword coined the term "zombie nouns." These are words that used to be lively verbs but turned into lifeless abstractions ending in -tion, -ment, -ance, -ence, -sion.

Zombie nouns are abstract, heavy words that make your essay sound like a policy report instead of a personal story.

Zombie: "The implementation of the tutoring program was a success." **Alive:** "I started a tutoring program, and it worked."

Zombie nouns bury the action in lifeless forms. Admissions officers want to see you acting.

If your writing is full of implementation, authorization, utilization, and documentation, it's time for an exorcism.

Hunt for zombie nouns in your essay. When you find one, ask: "Can I rewrite this as a verb?" Usually, the answer is yes.

KILL CONFUSION

Rule 1: Kill the Passive Voice

Passive voice isn't grammatically incorrect. Let's clear that up first. "Never use passive voice" would be oversimplifying. But when you use passive voice, it hides the person doing the action, and that creates fog.

"It was decided that the budget would be reduced" leaves readers asking: Who decided? Your brain immediately tries to fill in the blank, wasting energy.

Compare: *"The board slashed the budget by 30%."*

Now we know who did what. The sentence is shorter, more vivid, and more energetic. "Slashed" beats "would be reduced."

Passive voice creates distance. It's the language of bureaucracy, of people trying not to be pinned down. When a politician says *"mistakes were made,"* they're using passive voice to dodge blame. When a company writes *"your account has been suspended,"* they're hiding behind the system. Nobody wants to say "we suspended your account" because that sounds like a choice, like someone clicked a button.

And that's exactly the point. Active voice makes writing feel human. It reminds readers that behind every decision, every action, every event, there's a person or group making choices.

Let's be honest about the exceptions, because they exist.

Exception 1: When the receiver matters more than the doer

"Kennedy was assassinated in Dallas" focuses on Kennedy, not on Oswald. That's the right emphasis. If you wrote *"Oswald assassinated Kennedy in Dallas,"* you'd be putting the spotlight on the wrong person.

"The vaccine was developed in record time," emphasizes the achievement, not which specific lab did it. Sometimes that's what you want.

Exception 2: When you don't know who did it

"My car was broken into last night." You don't know who did it. Active voice would require you to write *"Someone broke into my car,"* which works fine, but the passive isn't wrong here.

Exception 3: When you want to soften blame or dodge responsibility

"Your application was rejected" feels gentler than *"We rejected your application."* Companies know this. It's manipulative, but it works.

These exceptions should be *choices*, not defaults. Use passive voice when it genuinely serves your purpose, not because you're too lazy to find the subject.

Rule 2: Kill Vagueness (Be Clear and Specific)

Vagueness is the enemy of personal statements. General words like "things," "stuff," "issues," "good," and "bad" don't help admissions officers picture your story.

"She had a meaningful experience" is vague. "She watched the sunrise over the lake" is concrete (you can almost step into it).

Here is a 3-step test to know if a writing is concrete:

1) Can I visualize it?

If a camera could record it, it's concrete. If it's just a label ("progress," "support," "impact"), it's vague.

Strong writing replaces labels with scenes, actions, and numbers.

If you cannot visualize something, you won't remember it. This distinction separates concrete language from abstract language. Concrete words create images. Abstract words fade away. When you say "efficient," nothing materializes in your mind. But when you say "saves you 40 minutes every morning," You can feel that time. It has weight.

2) Can I falsify it?

When you write something true or false, you put your head on the chopping block. People sit up. Our ears prick up because stakes exist. The trick is to point, not to talk. Instead of saying someone is "intelligent," you might say "reads on the tube." Instead of "good-looking," you say "looks like Ryan Gosling." These are statements that can be verified or disproven. They ground your claim in reality. The difference matters because adjectives are wallpaper. Facts are load-bearing walls.

3) **Can nobody else say this?**

For personal statements, this means: Does this claim belong to your actual life, or could it belong to anyone?

When you write "I'm passionate about helping others," you've written something that applies to thousands of applicants in the same pile. When you write "I spent three summers cataloging oral histories from my grandmother's neighborhood, and discovered that the street I grew up on had been renamed twice," you've written something only you could write. The second statement is specific enough that it cannot be borrowed, recycled, or claimed by someone else.

If a stranger could read your personal statement and insert their own name without changing a single sentence, you haven't written about yourself. You've written a template. And templates are forgettable.

Your specificity comes from the irreducible details of your life, not the conclusions you draw from them, but the actual facts. You didn't "overcome adversity." You worked nights at a convenience store while taking the SAT hungover, because your mom had the flu. You didn't "develop leadership skills." You were the only person who showed up to the debate team meeting for three weeks, so you ran it alone until others came back. You didn't "find your passion." You rewatched the same documentary fourteen times and started teaching it to friends without being asked.

The stronger your personal statement, the less it could apply to anyone else. Specificity is not decoration. It is evidence that you are paying attention to your own life, that you notice what makes your path different from the standard path. That noticing is what admissions officers actually want to see.

These three sub-rules are not suggestions. They are the minimum standard. Apply them to everything.

If you get three ***nos***, you've probably written a lot of rubbish.

If you get three ***yeses***, you're onto something.

Think of your essay as a movie. If you say "I faced challenges," admissions officers see nothing. But if you say "I walked three miles to school every morning across muddy fields," they see the scene.

In college essays, where hundreds claim identical qualities, concrete details become your only differentiation. Everyone says they're hardworking. Only you can describe the specific work you did.

Rule 3: Kill Negative Sentences

Negatives make writing harder to read. They force readers to process what something *isn't* before figuring out what it *is*.

Instead of saying what something isn't, say what it is.

- Weak: *"It is unlikely that the fees will not be raised next year."*
- Strong: *"The fees will likely increase next year."*

Notice how the second version feels direct and easy to grasp? It also feels more confident.

This doesn't mean you should avoid negative words altogether. Sometimes, they're necessary. But whenever possible, rewrite into a positive statement. It makes your meaning sharper and your prose stronger.

Negatives make readers stop, flip the thought, then move on. Positives land right away.

When you write "He was not honest," the reader first imagines honesty, then erases it.

"He was dishonest" goes straight to the point. "She did not remember" feels roundabout; "She forgot" is direct.

Here's the test: if your sentence uses *not* with a weak word, swap it for the strong word that says the truth outright.

Examples:

Instead of "He was not willing," → write "He refused."

Instead of "She is not often late," → write "She is usually on time."

Instead of “It’s not impossible,” → write “It’s possible.”

The more direct your words, the stronger your writing.

KILL POOR STRUCTURE

Rule 1: Kill Long, Wandering Beginnings

Often, applicants stuff their actual point at the end of sentences; behind context, background details, throat-clearing that delays understanding. Readers want the conclusion immediately, and then they'll accept your reasoning.

Compare:

Buried point: *“Given the problems of unfriendly climate, poor infrastructure, various militant groups vying for bribes, and a lack of refrigerated trucks, it was difficult for the government to transport food to the village.”*

Front-loaded point: *“It was difficult for the government to deliver food to the village because of harsh weather, poor infrastructure, militant groups demanding bribes, and a shortage of refrigerated trucks.”*

The second version answers “*what's the problem?*” before justifying itself. You read “difficult” and immediately understand the situation. Then the reasons come as proof, not preamble.

In the weak version, your brain receives four obstacles before learning what they're obstacles to. You're holding information in temporary storage. That's wasted mental energy.

The strong version works like directions: destination first, route second. “Difficult to deliver food” establishes the framework. Now “harsh weather” makes immediate sense. It's *why* delivery is difficult.

Admissions readers process hundreds of essays. They're evaluating, not reading for pleasure. If your first sentence meanders through context before reaching substance, you've lost attention.

The first option: *Having grown up in a household where my parents, both immigrants who worked multiple jobs and often came home exhausted, rarely had time to help with schoolwork, I learned to teach myself.”*

The second option: *“I quickly figured out how to learn on my own. With my parents juggling multiple jobs, there was never enough time for them to sit down and help with schoolwork.”*

The second delivers the claim (“I quickly figured out how to learn on my own”) as your hook. The explanation becomes *proof* rather than an excuse.

Rule 2: Kill Loose Sentences & Awful Rhythm

Loose sentences string clauses together with “and... and... and...” They feel flat, exhausting, and force readers to hold too much information at once.

Admissions Officers read hundreds of essays in sequence. When every sentence has the same length and structure, your writing becomes auditory wallpaper that’s present but unheard.

Rhythm creates attention. A short sentence after several long ones hits like a drumbeat. It signals: *this matters, pay attention here.*

When sentences flow well, readers absorb information effortlessly. When rhythm drags or stutters, readers work harder and retain less. In college essays where admissions officers read quickly, good rhythm is a competitive advantage.

Good writing mixes simple and complex sentences. Use statements, commands, questions, and exclamations. Variety keeps readers engaged.

A quick example:

Loose (before): “I studied for my exams, and I joined the robotics team, and I worked part-time, and I still helped my family with chores.”

Tight (after): “I studied for exams while leading the robotics team and working part-time. At home, I still helped my family.”

The tight version splits one breathless sentence into two purposeful ones. The first establishes workload. The second (shorter, separate) emphasizes that you did even more. This creates rhythm: information, pause, emphasis.

Fix 1: The “And” Problem

Coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or, so) are grammatically fine but rhythmically dangerous. They pile information without hierarchy: everything has equal weight, so nothing stands out.

Loose: "I wanted to help my community, and I organized a food drive. I collected 500 cans, and I delivered them to the local shelter. And the manager thanked me."

This reads like a list read aloud without pauses. Every clause feels identical.

Tight: "I organized a food drive for my community. After collecting 500 cans, I delivered them to the local shelter. The manager thanked me personally."

Breaking into three sentences creates hierarchy. The first states the goal. The second shows action and result. The third, the shortest, captures the human moment. Now readers know what matters most.

Fix 2: Avoid Comma Splices

Loose sentences often contain comma splices: two independent clauses joined by just a comma. This is both grammatically wrong and rhythmically weak.

Comma splice: "I studied all night, I aced the exam."

Three solutions:

1. **Two sentences:** "I studied all night. I aced the exam." (Creates a hard stop)
2. **Coordination:** "I studied all night and aced the exam." (Merges the ideas)
3. **Subordination:** "After studying all night, I aced the exam." (Shows causation, usually strongest)

The subordination version works best because it reveals the *relationship* between clauses, not just the sequence.

Fix 3: Strategic Sentence Variation

When you vary sentence length deliberately, you control what readers notice.

No variation: "I worked at the restaurant. I learned customer service. I practiced patience. I earned money for college."

Each sentence has identical structure (subject-verb-object) and similar length. Nothing stands out. Readers glaze over.

Strategic variation: "I worked at the restaurant for two years, learning customer service while practicing patience with difficult customers. I earned \$3,000 for college. More importantly, I learned that respect costs nothing but means everything."

Now the middle sentence (shortest) emphasizes the concrete achievement (\$3,000). The final sentence (longer) delivers the insight. The variation tells readers where to focus.

Compare these two:

Flat: "I studied biology. I joined the robotics club. I helped my brother. I read books."

Alive: "My brother asked about derivatives. I tried explaining with the textbook graph—nothing. Grabbed his basketball, showed him speed changing. He nodded. Later, I thought: Why did that work?"

The difference is rhythm. Short sentences punch. Long ones expand. Together, they keep readers awake.

Common Rhythm Mistakes

Mistake 1: Starting Every Sentence the Same Way

Wrong: "I joined the debate team. I learned public speaking. I competed in tournaments. I won regionals."

Fix: Vary how sentences begin using transitional words or dependent clauses.

"After joining the debate team, I learned public speaking. During tournaments, I competed fiercely. By regionals, I had won."

Mistake 2: Never Using Fragments

Sentence fragments are technically incorrect but rhetorically powerful when used sparingly for emphasis.

"I practiced every day for three months, drilling the same speech until I could recite it backward. Then competition day arrived. I froze."

"I froze" is technically a fragment, but its shortness creates emotional impact, and that's exactly what you want.

Mistake 3: Overusing Semicolons

Semicolons join related sentences with balance but generate little rhythm. Too many feel formal and stiff.

Wrong: "I studied hard; I wanted good grades; I needed scholarships."

Better: "I studied hard. I wanted good grades. I needed scholarships."

Best: "I studied hard because good grades meant scholarships—and scholarships meant college."

The best version shows *causation*. Readers understand the stakes immediately.

Your body knows good rhythm. Read your essay aloud.

- If you run out of breath before a sentence ends, it's too long.
- If you sound like a robot reading a list, your sentences are too similar.

Good prose sounds conversational when read aloud; that's natural, not casual. You should *hear* pauses where commas and periods create them. You should *feel* emphasis where short sentences land.

Admissions officers might not read your essay aloud, but they *feel* the rhythm as they scan. Bad rhythm makes them work harder. Good rhythm makes them remember you.

Rule 3: Kill Repetition

You only have 650 words. Don't waste them saying the same thing three different ways.

Repetitive:

"I want to be a doctor to help people. Helping people is what drives me. The desire to help people motivates my interest in medicine."

Fresh:

"My neighbor burned her hand on the stove. I ran home, grabbed aloe from our garden, and rubbed it on the burn. Her face relaxed."

Notice how the fresh version avoids repeating "help people." It says the same idea in a new, vivid way.

If you find yourself writing the same phrase twice, keep the stronger one and delete the weaker. Use the freed-up space to add a new layer of your story.

PART III: COLLEGE-ESSAY SPECIFIC RULES

The rules from the earlier section improve your general writing skills, but personal statements are different entities. They require surgical precision, narrative power, and the courage to be vulnerable. Here are the specific rules that will transform your drafts from generic to unforgettable.

Structure

Introduction: The Hook

The most important sentence in any essay is the first one. Admissions officers read hundreds of essays. They're tired, caffeinated, speed-reading through mountains of applications. You have one sentence to make them pause them from skimming through.

What makes a powerful hook?

1. Start in the middle of the action. No context. No explanation. Not a long, loose dependent clause. Start with the most interesting, core, and ripe part of your story.

- Antuan Groize was this decrepit old man in his 50s, and he was obsessed with *Boeing 787*, the *Dreamliner*.
- At the time, I was suffering from some form of existential malaise.
- “Successful people tend to be persistent.” - Paul Graham

”All you have to do is write one true sentence. Write the truest sentence that you know.” This advice comes from Hemingway's memoir *A Moveable Feast*.

2. Use dialogue. Dialogues perfectly work as hooks because they prompt the writer to start right in the middle of an ongoing action. So, this is just a variation of our first approach.

- “Your turn,” my opponent smirked.
- “This doesn't make sense,” I muttered, staring at my own blood work results.

3. Present a contradiction. Contradictions are surprising, thus they grab the attention.

- I spent three years building a robot that would eventually teach me I knew nothing about friendship.

-
- Plato would be a dictator in our age.

What to avoid:

- **Do NOT retell the prompt.** "I have always been interested in..." is a generic opening.
- **Do NOT start with a famous quote.** Unless you have an extraordinarily unique spin, famous quotes are overused and gimmicky.
- **Do NOT begin with sweeping generalizations.** "Throughout history..." or "In today's society..." are academic openers that kill personality.
- **Do NOT explain what you're about to explain.** Just start the story.
- **Do NOT start with overdrama.** Something like "OMG," or "BOOM."

Think of your favorite TV shows. The best episodes don't waste time with "Previously on..." They place you in the middle of the action. Your essay should do the same. Trust that context will reveal itself as the story unfolds. Open without much background. You can give the context later.

Middle: Building Your Narrative

Rule 1: Use Internal Cliffhangers to Maintain Momentum

An internal cliffhanger creates micro-suspense at the end of paragraphs. This keeps the admissions officer reading instead of moving to the next application.

End a paragraph with a sentence that raises a question, hints at a revelation, or creates tension that can only be resolved by continuing to read.

Example:

Weak ending: "I learned a lot from that experience and grew as a person."

Strong ending with internal cliffhanger: "It wasn't until three months later that I understood what she'd really meant."

Weak ending: "Volunteering opened my eyes to people's real needs."

Strong ending: "Anvar aka's daughter didn't want food, books, or money—she needed what I couldn't donate: happiness."

Each cliffhanger creates a specific question in the reader's mind. The reader **must** continue to the next paragraph to find out.

Conclusion: The Landing

The perfect ending should take your readers slightly by surprise and yet seem exactly right. They didn't expect the essay to end so soon, or so abruptly, or to say what it said. But they know it when they see it.

So, end with insight, not a summary.

Just summarizing your entire experience in the last sentence shows that you are a lazy writer, not a good sight before the admissions officer.

What NOT to do:

- Summarize what you just told the reader
- State "In conclusion..." or "To sum up..."
- Simply restate your thesis or main point
- End with a generic statement about your future
- Force a famous quote.

What TO do:

End with a specific insight, image, or moment that feels both surprising and inevitable, something that could only come from the journey you've just described.

1. "While my mentor's salsa dancing recommendation was not my life-changing cure, it came to represent something equally important: a reminder of my *cognitive biases* and a declaration of revolution against self-imposed limitations to expression."
2. "Looking back on this summer 20 years from now, I probably won't remember the miles covered or the summits reached. But I'll remember the feeling of plunging into cool water, my clothes sticking to my body. And I'll remember old-guy Alexei."
3. "Peyton Fahrquhar was dead; his body, with a broken neck, swung gently from side to side beneath the timbers of the Owl Creek bridge." ~ *On Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge*, Ambrose Bierce
4. "I am thinking of aurochs and angels, the secret of durable pigments, prophetic sonnets, the refuge of art. And this is the only immortality you and I may share, my Lolita." ~ *Lolita*, Vladimir Nabokov

Notice how each ending returns to a concrete image, contains a revelation, shows growth (if there is) without explicitly stating "I grew," feels earned by the narrative, and leaves the reader with a lasting impression.

If possible, bring the lead story full circle. It gives symmetry and pleases the reader. Often a quotation works best, especially surprising ones.

Additional Personal Statement Rules

Rule 1: Show Your Thought Process, Not Just Your Achievements

Admissions officers can evaluate what you did (impact, initiative) from your Activities List. So you have to dedicate your personal statement to fully conveying your worldview, your thoughts, purpose, pathos, or anything significant about you. Your essay can also reveal your thinking processes: how you approach problems, how you learn from failure, and how you make connections between ideas.

Rule 2: Throw Your IELTS Band 8.0 Away

Partially because many Uzbek students start their English journey with IELTS, they end up developing strict academic writing. Academic writing is not bad, but it is not suitable for personal statements.

We will show two good and bad example sets for you to understand.

What to avoid:

- **Academic formality:** "Throughout my tenure as president of the robotics club, I endeavored to foster an environment conducive to collaborative innovation."
- **Passive voice:** "The lesson was learned by me through this experience."
- **Unnecessarily fancy or jargon words:** "I utilized my cognitive faculties to ascertain the solution."
- **Five-paragraph essay structure:** Introduction with thesis statement, three body paragraphs with topic sentences, conclusion that restates everything.

What to do instead:

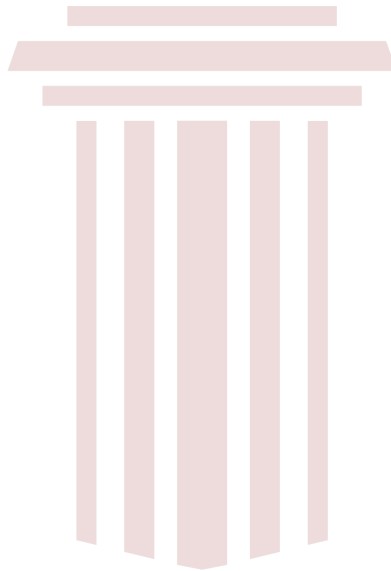
Go through our "Kill" section)

Rule 3: Shitty First Drafts

Even the greatest writers can't produce an elegant piece with their first draft alone. The first draft is not for the reader. It's for you. Its sole purpose is to exist.

In fact, we can say that your first shitty draft is some great idea from your morning pages (chapter 1). If you remember the section, morning pages are entirely about pouring down whatever you have in your mind. You just want to get everything out of that cloudy state and visualize.

Shitty drafts are normal. If you want to build a building, you don't start with the first floor. You start with meters-long foundation. Those morning pages and shitty drafts are your foundation.



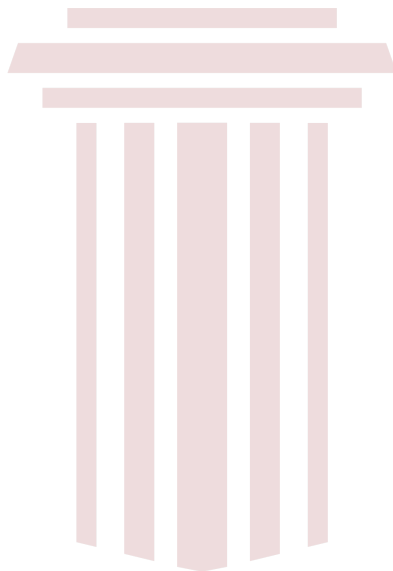
Beyond Rules

Rules sharpen craft, but writing isn't math. Style comes from knowing when to bend the rules.

Experiment. Try sentences long and short, plain and lyrical. Not all rules fit every page.

Seek feedback. Fresh eyes catch what you missed. Confusion, clutter, or tone gone astray.

Know when to stop. Revision can stretch forever, but clarity and rhythm eventually click. When the words feel inevitable, the piece is ready.



Summary of Chapter

Once you've completed your morning pages, you have raw material: unfiltered thoughts, experiences, and ideas that contain the seeds of a compelling personal statement. Now comes the actual writing process.

Writing happens in stages. First, you draft. Take the insights from your morning pages and shape them into early versions of your essay. These drafts won't be perfect. They shouldn't be. A draft's job is to get ideas on the page where you can see them, test them, and improve them.

As you write multiple drafts, apply the rules from this book systematically. Each rule, whether it's about concrete details, sentence clarity, or story structure, makes your writing sharper. Use one draft to strengthen your opening. Use another to cut unnecessary words. Use a third to add specific examples that prove your points rather than just state them.

The rules work because they're simple and clear. Apply them one at a time. Revise deliberately. Each pass through your draft should make the writing better: clearer sentences, stronger verbs, more vivid details, tighter logic.

By the time you finish drafting and applying these rules, you'll have a personal statement that's close to final. But "close" isn't done. The next chapter covers editing, the final stage where you polish every sentence until the writing is exactly right. That's where good writing becomes great writing.

For now, focus on getting your drafts written and using the "kills" to improve them systematically. The morning pages give you the raw data. The drafts turn that data into something readable. The rules make it convincing, compelling.



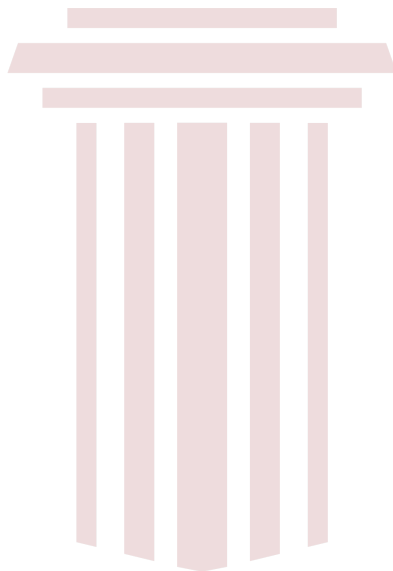
Post-Writing

Editing is equally important as writing itself.

Most writers misunderstand revision. They think it's fixing typos, adjusting commas, or polishing a few rough patches. That's proofreading. Revision is something else entirely: it's seeing your work again and being willing to destroy what needs destroying.

Ernest Hemingway rewrote the ending of *A Farewell to Arms* **thirty-nine** times. When asked what the problem was, he said, "***Getting the words right.***"

That's revision. Getting the words right.



I: REVISION FRAMEWORK

The Distance Problem

You wrote your essay. You know what you meant to say. So when you read it back, your brain fills in gaps, smooths over rough spots, and supplies context that isn't actually on the page. You're not reading what's there; you're reading what you think is there.

The solution: distance.

After finishing your draft, put it away. Don't look at it for at least three days. A week is better. Your mind needs to forget what you were trying to say so you can see what you actually said.

When you return, you'll spot problems that were invisible before:

- The paragraph that repeats the previous one
- The sentence that leads nowhere
- The word you used four times in two paragraphs
- The logic gap you bridged mentally but never explained

Professional writers talk about "killing your darlings." That clever metaphor you love? That perfect sentence you crafted? If it doesn't serve the story, it dies. Attachment blinds you. Distance reveals.

The Five-Pass System

Revision is five separate tasks. Trying to fix everything at once guarantees you'll miss things. Each pass has a single purpose.

Pass 1: The Clarity Pass

Read as if you know nothing about the topic. Pretend you're the admissions officer who just picked up your essay after reading fifty others.

Ask at every paragraph:

- Can someone unfamiliar with my story follow this?
- Have I assumed knowledge I never provided?
- Does this sentence connect logically to the one before it?

Mark every moment where you pause, reread, or think "wait, what?" Those are clarity breaks. Fix them.

Example:

Before: "After the incident with the microscope, I changed my approach."

After: "After I accidentally broke the microscope's condenser lens while adjusting the focus, I learned to slow down and check the settings before touching equipment."

The first version assumes the reader knows about an incident you never described. The second shows what happened and what it meant.

Clarity checklist:

- No unexplained references to "it," "this," or "that"
- No assumed knowledge the reader doesn't have
- Each paragraph follows logically from the previous one
- Transitions exist where needed
- Technical terms are explained or avoided

Pass 2: The Voice Pass

Read your entire essay out loud. Not in your head, but actually speak the words.

Your mouth reveals what your brain hides:

- Sentences too long to say in one breath (divide them up)
- Awkward phrasing that makes you stumble (rewrite)
- Unintentional repetition (you'll hear the same word echoing)
- Rhythm problems (monotonous sentences putting you to sleep)

If you can't say it smoothly, your reader can't read it smoothly either.

Ernest Hemingway finished a manuscript and read it aloud to his grandchildren. Not because they were his target audience, but because reading aloud to an actual person forces you to hear every weak spot. You can't skim past problems when someone's listening.

Mark Twain did the same with his family. He'd gather them in the living room and read chapters aloud, watching their faces. When they looked confused, he'd mark the page.

When they laughed at something meant to be serious, he'd mark that too. He wanted to make sure that his writing delivered what he intended.

You don't need grandchildren or a family reading circle. Just read it aloud to yourself. Record it on your phone if that helps. Then listen back.

Voice Pass Checklist

- ☐ Sentences are short enough to read in two breaths
- ☐ No tongue-twisters or awkward phrasing
- ☐ Sentence rhythm varies (mix of short and long)
- ☐ Tone feels conversational, not mechanical
- ☐ No unintentional rhymes or repeated sounds

Pass 3: The Rule Hunt

Now you're looking for specific technical violations. Go through systematically:

Wordiness check:

- Circle every instance of "very," "really," "quite," "actually," "basically"
- Flag phrases like "at this point in time," "due to the fact that," "in order to"
- Delete them unless you can justify each one

Zombie noun check:

- Search for words ending in -tion, -ment, -ance, -ence
- Ask: "Can I rewrite this as a verb?"
- "The implementation of the program" becomes "We implemented the program"

Passive voice check:

- Find every sentence with "was" or "were"
- Ask: "Who did this action?"
- Put the actor first: "The lesson was learned by me" becomes "I learned the lesson"

Vagueness check:

- Highlight words like "things," "stuff," "good," "bad," "interesting"
- Replace with concrete specifics
- "It was a good experience" becomes "I learned how to solder circuit boards without burning myself"

Rule hunt checklist:

- ☐ All empty filler words removed
- ☐ Zombie nouns rewritten as active verbs
- ☐ Passive constructions changed to active (unless necessary)
- ☐ Vague wording replaced with concrete specifics
- ☐ Adjectives and adverbs reduced by 50%

Pass 4: The Cutting Pass

Your essay must lose at least 10% of its words. This is non-negotiable.

Go paragraph by paragraph:

- What's the point of this paragraph?
- If it were gone, what would the essay lose?
- If the answer is "nothing important," delete it

Look for these common padding patterns:

Throat-clearing: Sentences that prepare the reader for information but don't provide information

- "It is important to note that..." → Just note it
- "I would like to explain..." → Just explain it

Repetition: Saying the same thing three different ways

- Find the strongest version
- Delete the other two

Hedging: Qualifying every statement until it means nothing

- "I think maybe this might possibly have had some effect" → "This changed things"

Decoration: Adjectives and adverbs that don't add meaning

- "She quickly ran" → "She sprinted"
- "The extremely difficult problem" → "The problem stumped me for three days"

Annie Dillard said, "You can save some sentences, like bricks. It will be a miracle if you can save some of the paragraphs, no matter how excellent in themselves or hard-won."

Translation: be ruthless when you are killing the clutter.

Cutting pass checklist:

- ☐ Essay is at least 10% shorter than previous draft
- ☐ Every paragraph serves a clear purpose
- ☐ No repetitive ideas across paragraphs
- ☐ No throat-clearing introductions
- ☐ No decorative sentences that just "sound good"

Pass 5: The Fresh Eyes Pass

This is where you need another human.

Not your parents (they'll be too impressed that you wrote anything at all). Not your best friend (they'll be too kind). You need someone who will tell you the truth without worrying about your feelings.

And if you want to get more feedback on your personal statements, we would suggest this list of the people you should (probably) get your feedback from:

- Someone who you know with the best English (supposing you write the essay in English)
- Someone whom you consider the smartest
- And a family member who you deem close to yourself

Getting Useful Feedback

Bad feedback: "I really liked it! It's great! You're such a good writer!"

Good feedback: "I got confused in paragraph three when you jumped from the lab to your grandmother's kitchen. The connection wasn't clear."

Bad feedback tells you nothing useful. Good feedback shows you exactly where the writing broke down.

How to Ask for Feedback

Don't say: "Can you read my essay and tell me what you think?"

Say: "Can you read my essay and mark anywhere you got confused, anywhere you had to reread a sentence, and anywhere you felt like I was padding or repeating myself?"

Give your reader specific things to look for. General questions produce general (useless) feedback.

Questions to Ask Your Reader

After they've read it once:

- "What do you think this essay is about?" (If they can't answer clearly, your main point is buried)
- "What do you remember most?" (That's what's actually landing)
- "Where did you get bored or confused?" (That's where to revise)
- "Did any part feel like I was trying too hard to sound impressive?" (That's where your authentic voice disappeared)

After they've read it a second time:

- "Point to three sentences you'd cut"
- "Circle any word you think I used too many times"
- "Underline anything that sounded generic, like anyone could have written it"

Real Examples From Actual Students

Example 1: The Robotics Essay

First draft: "Being on the robotics team was a very transformative experience that taught me a lot about leadership and perseverance. We had many challenges throughout the season, but we worked together to overcome them."

Feedback from peer: "I don't see any robotics here. You could be talking about literally any team activity. Also, what challenges? What did you actually do?"

Revised draft: "At 2 am before the competition, our robot's claw mechanism kept jamming. I wanted to rebuild it my way: slower but reliable. My teammate insisted we try his untested pneumatic design. I had four hours to decide whether to trust him."

The revision shows specific details, creates tension, and reveals how the student actually thinks under pressure.

Example 2: The Volunteer Essay

First draft: "Volunteering at the community center showed me the importance of giving back and helping those less fortunate than myself."

Feedback from peer: "This sounds like every volunteer essay ever written. What actually happened there that made you think differently about something?"

Revised draft: "Mrs. Rezade taught me how to say 'thank you' in Farsi before I taught her how to say it in Uzbek. That's when I realized I'd been volunteering for the wrong reasons."

The revision contains a specific moment, shows self-awareness, and hints at a larger realization without explaining it to death.

Example 3: The Reading Essay

First draft: "I have always loved reading because books transport you to different worlds and teach you new perspectives."

Feedback from peer: "Everyone who likes reading says this. What book actually changed how you think about something specific?"

Revised draft: "Page 47 of *The Stranger* asks whether we're defined by what we do or what we feel about what we do. I didn't have an answer until I watched my brother apologize for something he didn't think was wrong."

The revision connects a specific moment in a specific book to a specific moment in the student's life. Nobody else could write this sentence.

Common Mistakes in the Revision Process

Mistake 1: Revising While You Draft

Don't edit the first sentence until you've written the last one. Perfectionism during drafting kills momentum. You'll spend an hour polishing paragraph one and never reach paragraph five.

Julia Cameron calls this "the censor," the voice that judges every sentence as you write it. The censor belongs in revision, not in drafting.

Mistake 2: Only Looking for Things to Add

Most of the revision should be subtraction. If your essay grows longer with each draft, you're decorating instead of improving. Every revision pass should make the essay tighter.

Mistake 3: Defending Your Choices

When someone says, "I got confused here," don't explain what you meant. Just mark it and fix it. If one reader was confused, the admissions officer might be too.

Your job isn't to explain yourself to your peer reviewer. Your job is to rewrite so clearly that the explanation becomes unnecessary.

Mistake 4: Changing Everything Based on One Opinion

Get feedback from at least three readers. If all three mark the same paragraph as confusing, that paragraph is confusing. If only one person mentions it, they might be the outlier.

Feedback is data. Collect enough data to see patterns.

Mistake 5: Stopping Too Soon

Most students think "good enough" means "no obvious mistakes." Wrong. "Good enough" means "every sentence is necessary and clear."

If you haven't cut anything painful, you haven't revised deeply enough.

II: DIAGNOSTIC TESTS

The Paragraph Isolation Test

Copy each paragraph into its own document. Read it completely separately from the rest of the essay.

Ask:

- Does this paragraph have a purpose?
- Does it advance the story or deepen understanding?
- If this paragraph disappeared, what would the essay lose?

If the answer is "nothing important," delete the paragraph. If the answer is "some context," ask whether that context could be woven into another paragraph instead.

This test reveals paragraphs that exist only because you wrote them, not because the essay needs them.

The Sentence Isolation Test

Same idea, smaller scale. Put each sentence on its own line with space between them.

Look at each sentence individually:

- Is this sentence doing work?
- Could this sentence be shorter?
- Does this sentence repeat something I already said?
- Does this sentence sound like me or like someone trying to sound academic?

George Orwell's rule: "If it is possible to cut a word out, always cut it out."

III: FINISHING STRONG

When to Stop Revising

You could revise forever. At some point, you need to declare the essay finished.

Signs you're done:

- You can read it aloud without stumbling
- Every paragraph serves a clear purpose
- You've cut everything cuttable
- Three different readers understood it clearly
- You've rewritten the weak spots multiple times
- Further changes would just be rearranging, not improving

Signs you're not done yet:

- You still cringe at certain sentences
- Readers keep marking the same paragraph as confusing
- You know you're hiding behind vague language somewhere
- The ending feels rushed or generic
- You haven't read it aloud yet
- You finished it yesterday

The Final Read

Before you submit, do one last read with this mindset: You're the admissions officer. You've just read thirty essays. You're tired. You're skeptical. You've seen every cliché.

Does this essay make you stop and pay attention? Does it show you something specific about how this student thinks? Could anyone else have written it?

If yes, you're done.

If no, you're not.

The Complete Revision Checklist

Use this for your final review:

Clarity

- ☐ A stranger could understand my story without additional context
- ☐ No unexplained jumps in logic or chronology
- ☐ Technical terms are explained or avoided
- ☐ Each paragraph connects clearly to the next

Voice

- ☐ Essay sounds conversational when read aloud
- ☐ No sentences longer than two breaths
- ☐ Rhythm varies throughout
- ☐ Sounds like me, not like someone trying to impress

Precision

- ☐ Cut all empty filler words (very, really, quite, etc.)
- ☐ Converted zombie nouns to active verbs
- ☐ Replaced passive voice with active
- ☐ Replaced vague words with concrete specifics

Efficiency

- ☐ Essay is 10% shorter than first draft
- ☐ Every paragraph serves a clear purpose
- ☐ No repetitive ideas
- ☐ No decorative sentences

Specificity

- ☐ Contains details only I could write
- ☐ Shows concrete moments, not abstract claims
- ☐ Names specific things (not "books" but "*The Stranger*")
- ☐ Nobody else could claim this essay as theirs

Structure

- ☐ First sentence hooks immediately
- ☐ Each paragraph ends with purpose or momentum
- ☐ Conclusion provides insight, not summary
- ☐ The essay feels complete

Feedback

- ☐ Three readers have reviewed it
- ☐ All confusing sections have been rewritten
- ☐ Generic phrases have been replaced
- ☐ Someone unfamiliar with my story understood it

You may as well download a separate version here: [Link](#)

The Hemingway Standard

When Hemingway said he rewrote the ending thirty-nine times, he wasn't bragging. He was describing the process. Getting the words right takes time.

Most students think one draft plus light editing equals done. Writers know better. The first draft is where you figure out what you're trying to say. The next five drafts are where you actually say it.

Your essay deserves more than one draft. Give it the revision it needs, not the revision that feels easiest.

Read it aloud. Get feedback. Cut ruthlessly. Repeat until the words are right.

That's how writing works. That's how getting the words right works.

Book Summary

Atlas has one lesson to teach: writing is thinking made visible.

Most students end up writing the same essay for colleges. They describe challenges, achievements, and lessons learned with a language that is vague, and insights that are generic. Those essays blur together because they write before thinking.

Atlas teaches to flip that process.

Pre-Writing (Chapter 1) establishes the foundation: thinking comes before writing. You spend time discovering what makes you genuinely different through morning pages: unfiltered writing that reveals your authentic voice. You research academic interests, mix ideas from different fields, and organize your thinking deliberately. The chapter ends with a test: if you can't explain why your idea matters beyond "it's correct," you're not ready to write yet. You need to repeat chapter 1's process.

Writing (Chapter 2) breaks down what makes writing good: simplicity, specificity, brevity, and voice. The theory section defines these principles clearly. Then the universal rules teach you how to kill wordiness (empty phrases, adjectives, zombie nouns), kill confusion (passive voice, vagueness, negatives), and kill poor structure (buried points, loose sentences, repetition). The college-essay specific rules cover structure (hooks that start in action, endings that provide insight) and voice (sounding human, not academic).

When you finish Chapter 2, you should have a complete personal statement draft that's clear, specific, and sounds authentically like you. It won't be perfect yet, that's what editing is for, but it should be substantially better than what most students submit as "final" versions.

Post-Writing (Chapter 3) systemizes editing through five passes: clarity (can a stranger follow this?), voice (does it sound natural read aloud?), rule hunt (did I violate any "kill" rules?), cutting (can I remove 10% without losing meaning?), and fresh eyes (what do readers actually understand?). Each pass has a specific purpose. You don't try to fix everything at once.

We tried to make sure that the progression mirrors what professional writers actually go through when writing. And we believe we did.

Students who can follow this progression will hopefully end up with great essays, the ones that get remembered by the admissions officers. Not entirely because the students had more impressive experiences, but because they thought more carefully about those experiences and expressed that thinking clearly.

The handbook includes examples throughout. Specific before-after revisions showing weak

writing turned into strong writing. Some of them are hypothetical; some come from actual student essays we've edited.

Two principles can be found in each chapter:

First, clear writing reveals clear thinking. If your essay feels confused, you haven't finished thinking yet. Return to pre-writing.

Second, specificity beats generalization every time. "I learned teamwork" tells nothing. "At 2 am, with the robot's claw jammed and four hours until competition, I had to decide whether to trust my teammate's untested design" shows how you think under pressure.

Atlas doesn't offer any shortcuts, and that's why it works. Morning pages demand consistency. Research takes effort. Revision hurts because you must cut sentences you love as they don't serve the essay. But this work produces essays that only you could write, essays built from your specific way of seeing the world rather than borrowed templates.

Most writing guides tell you what to do. This one shows you how to do it, then makes you practice until you can do it yourself.

If you want a formula for cranking out acceptable essays quickly, this isn't your book. If you want to develop genuine writing skill that serves you beyond college applications (in course-work, in professional communication, in any context where clear thinking matters) then follow the steps.

Start with morning pages. Think before you write. Apply the rules systematically. Revise until you get the words right.

Thank you for reading our book. We hope it was useful!

About the Authors

Umarbek Umarov is not a credentialist. He does not armor himself with degrees listed in descending font sizes, does not introduce himself with institutional affiliations, does not wave certificates as proof of thinking.

He is not a “public intellectual” in the modern mold. No TED talks packaging ideas into digestible narratives, no X (Twitter) threads performing insight for algorithmic favor, no podcast tour where the same anecdotes get polished through repetition until they lose their truth.

He is not building a personal brand. There is no optimization for various screen sizes, no carefully crafted origin story designed to inspire, no “full name + tagline” formula that consultants recommend.

He is not a specialist. Not purely a writer, not strictly a programmer, not exclusively a philosopher.

Umarbek exists at 20th.uz

He does not separate his interests into categories.

What he is not creating: dependencies.

He is not writing to be finished, not creating to be complete. His “atomic ideas” are explicitly works-in-progress. Not polished arguments, not defended theses, not conclusions.

He is not afraid of uncertainty, not pretending to have answers he doesn't have, not performing confidence where curiosity belongs.

What remains when we remove what Umarbek is not? Not a carefully constructed public persona. Not a performance optimized for metrics. Not a brand designed for scalability.

A space. Deliberate, open, unpretentious.

Husan Isomiddinov, in his own words:

I took two gap years.

Not because college is useless (it is useful, in fact). Because sitting in the Tashkent building Agora can teach more than most syllabi would. I will go to college one day, though; when the time is right, when I want it, rather than need it.

I read political philosophy in high school (Rousseau, Arendt, Ibn Khaldun), then quit caring about politics after graduation. The field optimises (simply) for consensus and unanimity, not truth. It didn't feel like my thing.

Now I'm in AI and startups. Some say I am doing it because it's fashionable. Fair, everyone out there is vibecoding and building startups. But I choose startups because they are the exact opposite of politics. Startups are where actual construction happens, far away from the reaches of bureaucracy. Small teams, fast execution, and solutions that actually turn the wheel for good. It might be a bubble (and, in fact, it is), but it is the future anyway. The bubble doesn't pop and vanish. It stays.

I'm learning the technical foundations now (cognitive science, ML systems, the math underneath, etc). I sometimes question if this path is even where I belong (and that's fine, that's how we make decisions). But it's just the pure intellectual ambition of these "small-team-fast-execution" communities that excites me to contribute.

Beyond all academic and entrepreneurial interests, I am also a human being. I like physical fitness. A sharp mind, a peaceful spirit, and a healthy body—all that I aim for. I lift weights and I run. I've been to a few local and international marathon races. But never finished a 42km. Hopefully in 2026.

I also appreciate art of any sort. For me, art is about the expert mastery of a certain objective. Any sufficiently advanced work is indistinguishable from art. And I work to be an artist, whatever field I pursue.

You can also find me here: husanisomiddinov.com

Contacts

This handbook exists because students needed it. If you found it useful, tell others.

If you have questions about the book contents or want to discuss education or institutional partnerships, then you are welcome to reach out to us in below addresses.

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We read everything. Response time varies based on volume, but genuine inquiries get genuine responses.

